







Clockwise from below left: ITC Royal Bengal is the brand's second hotel in Kolkata; Welcomhotel By ITC Hotels, Hamsa Manali is surrounded by snow-clad Himalayan mountains; ITC Grand Chola in Chennai is a palatial tribute to the Chola dynasty; ITC Ratnadipa in Colombo is the brand's first international hotel

Facing page: Art has always been integral to the ITC Hotels experience

PIONEERING INDIAN LUXURY

But the narrative is not one of numbers. It is of the unique path the hotel chain carved in the world of experiential hospitality, as it boldly veered away from the good life as defined by five-star international brands. Instead, ITC Hotels' bastions of luxury became quintessentially Indian spaces.

"We believed that India had all the ingredients to create a hospitality experience that could be truly distinctive—our traditions of welcoming, our architecture, our art and craft, the extraordinary diversity of our cuisine, and above all, our instinctive warmth as a people," said Anil Chadha, Managing Director of ITC Hotels Limited. "The ambition was therefore not to replicate what already existed elsewhere, but to build a hospitality philosophy that was unmistakably our own."

So instead of looking outward, the company chose to look inward. The smallest detail reflects the local ethos of the destination of each hotel, such as the tapestry chosen for drapes and sofas—from exquisite crewel embroidery in its Pahalgam property that resembles a mountain chalet to rich ikat at ITC Kakatiya, Hyderabad. In Storii Jawai in Rajasthan, wildlife lovers set out to spot leopards from an intimate 15-key boutique style stay set amid dramatic granite boulders. During the stay, whether in a cottage or tented villa, they can savour Rajasthani fare like gatte ke sabzi and laal maas. At its spa, Kaya Kalp, the signatures focus on Indian wellness and Ayurvedic treatments.

"What makes a stay memorable is often something less tangible—the feeling that you have encountered a place rather than simply occupied a hotel room. India offers an ex-